publicly indicating a desire to play a leadership role in Asia.[41] Citing how crucial it was to keep India "out of the communist orbit," Dulles's deputy for the political conference had warned about Korea-related anti-India opinion damaging US-India relations.[42] And he had been proved correct.

In Washington in the aftermath of the Korean War, there was an effort to downplay any Asian leadership role for India and Nehru—a role many in the US had earlier advocated. Knowland, criticizing India for "yielding" to China, dismissed Nehru as the spokesman for all of Asia.[43] Dulles told Eisenhower that the US should avoid actions that would "establish Nehru as the leader of all South and Southeast Asia."[44] And American diplomats reported with satisfaction when differences between Nehru and other South Asian leaders on communism were apparent.[45]

Even beyond Washington, the Korean War and Delhi's mediatory role between China and the US took its toll on American public opinion of India. In January 1951, a quarter of those polled had said India could not be counted on to cooperate with the US; by April 1954 this number had climbed to 42 percent. In January 1952, 57 percent of those polled believed that India was neither on the American nor the Russian side; in April 1954, only 28 percent thought India was neutral, with 7 percent believing the Indian government was communist and 26 percent considering it to be pro-communist.[46]

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Korea was not the only Asian conflict that caused US-India strain; there was also the situation in Indochina, where Ho Chi Minh's Vietminh was taking on US ally France. US and Indian objectives in Southeast Asia were not entirely disparate. Eisenhower and Dulles believed that after the loss of China to the communist world, a loss in Vietnam—to the China-backed Vietminh—would be crippling. Even with an upswing in Sino-Indian relations, however, India had no interest in greater Chinese influence in the region.[47] And American officials acknowledged that Delhi desired neither a return to colonialism nor a turn to communism in the region nor "a further consolidation of external communist power."[48]

But, while their goals in Southeast Asia might have been similar, once again, India and the US had different ideas about the right approach. Nehru was critical of Washington's "purely military approach in aid of a colonial